

PART ONE

Mr. Eastons Story

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Story 1 4th of July 2015

I am riding around Baytown on my 650 Honda Shadow enjoying a beautiful day. My 56 Fairlane is at J.W.s getting some work done, the carb is clogged up and won't stay running. My brother has my Jeep. I think he does. I do a lot of meth and my days turn into weeks and memories bleed into each other. It's such a busy day for me (Mr. Easton). I'm a small-time meth dealer who has made some big connections and big enemies. The local narcotics agency knows what I do but can't catch me doing anything. They harass me all the time. As I cruise through town making my drops. My little ball of energy (Amber Lynn) and the super sexy Brandy Foxx are texting me to show

up at the party tonight. It'll be a great chance to hang out at Tim's house, make some easy sales, and not worry about anything but the chickies bouncing around in bathing suit tops (boobies make me smile). I'm headed to one of my best friend's house, J.D. and I are like brothers. The bike I say is mine is his. He called me one day to come check out a strange sound it was making and I have had it ever since. He has access to any of my vehicles anytime he needs one. I get to J.D.'s and I'm letting him know I'll be gone most of the day and all night so don't worry if I don't answer my phone. I take off around 2 to head to the party when I get to the beltway the breather has gotten loose and falls off while cruising around 70 and somehow I manage to catch it before it falls. I stop at Shell to put it back on and get a drink. I see one of the bolts is broken

off and I can't put it back on so I double bag it and jump back on the bike and I'm off to the party. Oh what fun it is here at Tim's with the girls, sex, drugs, music, and drinks. The party goes on and on. My pocket fills with money and empties of my party favors. I've ignored most of my clients throughout the day and now I'm texting them letting them know I'll be on my way back soon. As I'm saying my goodbyes Amber Lynn asks when I last ate because I look shaky and I am hypoglycemic. I tell her I am fine and start to walk out as Tim walks up to me and asks if he can take my bike for a ride around the block. I'm worried about it, but he has let me use his sports car a few times so I say sure. While Tim is gone my little ball of energy rolls a bowl and she grills me about the last time I've eaten. She thinks my sugar is getting low, my

hands are shaking. Tim pulls back up and I jump on the bike mad as hell Amber Lynn wouldn't drop the low-sugar thing. All this is new to me, I've only been hypoglycemic for three years. God saved my life three years ago and as a daily reminder of the gift he gave me I lost most of my sense of smell and taste for most of the last three years and my body no longer produces enough glucose. Small price to pay for my life. Thank you, God. I'm headed for the east side and it hits me. Damn it Amber Lynn was right I jump off at Wallisville Rd and go into Walmart. I need food quickly, I park my bike in a no-parking space and stumble inside. I make it to McDonald's and order my food and as I'm explaining my sugar is low and I'm about to fall out I pass out. I wake up to one of the employees giving me orange juice and an apple pie. The security guard who helped

me inside pops up and informs me the cops are on the way and I should leave, he says he knows I've got something on me I shouldn't. I'm weak still from the low sugar and can't even back my bike up so he does it for me I call J.W. to let him know to come look for me on I-10 East that the law is coming to where I am and I'm taking off. I tell him about falling out in McDonald's hang up and get on my bike. I tell the guard thanks for his help and start stuffing a burger in my mouth and drinking a soda. As I put the bike in gear I'm grateful that I can hold my balance long enough to get to the exit. As I get close to the road I'm thankful there is no traffic and I don't have to stop. I lean into the turn and let the wind rush through my hair as I run through the gears. There is no greater rush than knowing I'm too weak for this ride and could be pulled off and still push

the limits. I come to the next red light and the adrenaline is rushing through me and all thoughts of I'm too weak for this are brushed aside. I pull through the light and get on the freeway and my phone starts ringing nonstop. I merge with the fast-moving traffic and think there is no better feeling than being on my bike during the summer night. It's after midnight right now it's almost 1 AM. Damn, I've lost a lot of time, I said I was leaving the party around 10 PM. What happened during these missing hours? It happens a lot when my sugar crashes. I lose time before and after I fall out. I get on 10 East moving fast and as I pass Sheldon Rd traffic thins out and I open up the bike. The scenes start to blur as I come up to the San Jacinto River, I know I have to slow down. The updraft coming across the bridge is almost enough to pick my bike up when riding

normally. Now I can feel my phone again start to vibrate so I take the next exit. I pull through the 2100 exit off 10 East, I park my bike just past the BBQ Restaurant. I get off my bike stretch and get my phone out. I've got 40 missed calls from the last time I checked it at Walmart. I called the last person who called me, it was Goldie. She wants me because her dude slept with my ex and well have you seen me? I've been told no one wears a pair of pants like me. Goldie wants some meth and I let her know she will be my 1st stop. I'm talking with her sitting on my bike with both legs stretched out on the right side with my ankles crossed. For just a few seconds I tune her out and enjoy the night sounds. I tell her I want to take a shower when I get there to wash the road dust off me. I hang up the phone and as I do that someone runs up and knocks me off my

bike. I roll to my right to get up and my unknown attacker charges me. Just as I'm standing up catches me in a full-speed spear and takes me back down to my back. He starts raining down blows and I'm doing all I can to block and get out of the way. He rears back to drop a heavy blow down and I swing with all my might and hit him in the balls. He collapses on top of me and I struggle to get out from under him. I get to my feet just before him and try to stand my bike up and get gone. He comes at me again just as I get the bike up he grabs me and tosses me like a doll. I land face down and roll to my left this time and tuck to roll over. Just as I'm getting on my back my motorcycle is thrown on my. The frame hits right in my chest and the curve at the front digs into my shoulder. I'm pinned under the bike hands on both ends of the frame. I push

with all my strength, the bike lifts just enough for me to slide out from under it and before I can get up I am grabbed by both ankles and swung around. The back of my head hits the frame of the bike and I'm knocked out. I don't know how much time has passed by but I wake up between I-10 and SPUR 330 face down in a pool of water gagging and coughing not able to breathe. My boots are gone, my dope is gone, and when I get back to my bike my backpack is dumped out and my keys have been removed from the ignition. To top it all off I can't find my phone either. It takes me a good 30 minutes to find the keys and get the bike started. The last time I looked at my phone was 1:05 AM as I was ending the call. I'm closest to J.D.'s house so I go straight there. I'm so weak at this point from low sugar, the beating I took and the blood loss I can barely keep

the bike upright on the feeder. I'm coming up to the railroad tracks right before J.D.'s house and as I cross them I almost lose control of the bike from the small vibration that runs up from the forks. I take the U-turn at Baker and turn into J.D.'s neighborhood. Now my mind starts to process what happened. I've been going on autopilot since I was attacked. I pull into J.D.'s driveway and the garage door is up. He comes running outside yelling at me because no one has heard from me except Goldie and she doesn't know any of my clients or my friends and family. I put my hands up and tell JD "Look bro, I've had a very bad night and I'm not fixing to listen to any of your shit". At the same time, I'm saying all this I see the reality of the situation dawn in JD's eyes. He goes from yelling because no one has heard from me to hysterics. After all, I think he

said I look like I've been drug through hell then had a wreck then got beat up. I couldn't help but laugh because that's kinda what happened. I wave him into the garage and we lower the door so we can still see lights if they pull up in front of the house. J.D. asks me what happened and I tell him from Tim's house as I'm getting ready to leave to pull up in his driveway. Then I grab his phone and log into my phone through its IMEI and MAC. Gotta love backdoor apps. Unfortunately, my phone is turned off because I can't get it to ping its location. Yes, I am going after the man who did this. Thankfully J.D. and I are close enough that he has access to all contacts' email stuff so I run through and let all the ones in my inner circle know what has happened. The first one to show up is the newest one to my inner circle, lil C. He pulls up and comes in ready to ride

out then comes my big brother big C, and lastly Rob. Now lil C. comes blacked out with a sawed-off shotgun and a boxing game. He is 5'9" 170 LBS blue eyes and more swag than legal. We got close after he was in jail and I'm beefing with someone he knows and I get a phone call saying he is in jail and someone is breaking into his house. I tell the guy I'm getting ready to fight what's going on and say since we both know lil C. we can either set our shit to the side and go take care of his shit and then get back to us or deal with ours and then hope we are in time to save his house. Well, we both agreed to go save our friend's stuff first and then we can settle our differences. When lil C. found out how the play went down we met up after he got outta jail, shook hands, and he told me that I had earned his loyalty. Now my big brother ain't related but has

stood by my side through it all. He rescued me from homelessness and being broke when I came home from state jail. He helped me out every time I fell on my face. He has never questioned me he has always just been there. His is the loyalty I value the most. I love you, big bro. Now for the last man on the team. He is my family, big ole backwoods type. Quick and dangerous, stands 6'8" and 350 lbs and loves to be up close in a fight. He knows how to use a knife and for family, is always ready to get dirty. Rob and I haven't always known we were family. I had got robbed in June and some people pointed me in his direction as someone who could make people really sorry for any mistakes they have made. Well, I hired him to go get the person who robbed me and punish them with a bat, and in the middle of everything he says something to me that makes me

mad. I decide to go after him and the first thing I do is kidnap the person he was hired to kidnap. Well, that pissed him off. We keep going after each other and missing when someone we both know points out that we are related through our kids. We find this out at the very last minute. I'm sitting in a motel room waiting for him after making sure he knows where I'm at. Rob has an electronic lock pick and I have a computer set up in front of the door with pictures of our kids on the screen. His lockpick opens the door and he comes in with murder in his eyes. But once he sees the kids he stops and asks in a nervous voice "Why are the kids on the screen." I tell him the problem is I started this day wanting to kill him. He says that's not a problem because only one of us is going to leave this room alive. I tell him "Well here is the problem, these

kids are my family" and he says "Well put the gun down" and I can see the tension drain from his body. I put the gun down and he explodes toward me and wraps me up in a bear hug that I thought was gonna crush me. He says "We are family and all this shit is behind us". I'll always be here for you. Rob is the biggest and quickest to fly off the handle. I on the other hand usually try to be cool calm and collected. Lil C. is a local to Baytown and starts asking everyone he knows to see what they can find out. All five of us run in our circle with me being the one that overlaps all of us. We are all putting out a reward for info leading to whoever did this to me. None of us have any luck. As the adrenaline wears off the pain starts to set in and I realize I'm seriously hurt. My left arm is almost immobile but I don't let anyone know. I'm the one they look to for

guidance, I can't let them know all the after-effects from the attack. I barely sleep the rest of the night and when I wake up the cops have me by the arms. My sugar fell while I was sleeping and I stumbled outside the garage and started knocking on the neighbor's doors. Someone got scared and called the police, when they got there I was lying the next-door neighbor's yard without a shirt. Thankfully they see the beating I took and decide to ask what happened. I tell them I ate gravel last night on my bike. I get a chance to explain the low blood sugar stuff and as I finish J.D. comes walking out his front door telling the officers that I'm staying there and I have low blood sugar. They ask him my name and as soon as Easton leaves his mouth I get put in cuffs and searched. They find nothing because everything was stolen the night

before and right now I don't know why I don't have my wallet my sugar is low. After checking for warrants and finding none they let me go. It's such a bright day it hurts my eyes. J.D. and I go in the garage close the door and smoke a bowl. The only two ways to start your day are shardee O's or get straight to the point. So much needs to be done. I've been robbed twice in less than two months. The first time I lost everything I owned except the clothes on my back and the boots on my feet and this time they got my boots.

The Confrontation with Dago

The sting of losing my boots, on top of everything else, felt like a slap in the face. But I wasn't just some random street punk. My mind, still fuzzy from the beating and low sugar, began to piece together the few clear details: the precise, brutal efficiency

of the attack; the way my bike was tossed with such strength; the sheer, unbridled rage in his eyes before I blacked out. This wasn't just a robbery. This was personal. I knew who it was. The word had been trickling through the grapevine for weeks, ever since my crew started pushing into new territories, cutting into other people's profits. His name was Dago. And he had a big brother, a patched member of the Hells Angels, who saw me as an obstacle. The Hells Angels were always looking for fresh meat, for new recruits who could prove their loyalty and toughness. Dago, I'd heard, had been told by his brother that if he could "take out this no-name asshole" – meaning me, of course – then they would let him ride with them, give him his own colors. A chance to finally be more than just a hanger-on, to earn his place in the infamous club.

My current situation, bleeding and bootless by the freeway, was Dago's audition. And he'd done a damn good job of it. He'd probably been staking me out, waiting for the perfect moment of weakness. My sugar crash at Walmart, then me pulling over, exhausted and vulnerable, was an open invitation.

Now, the game had changed. It wasn't just about reclaiming my stolen dope and my boots. It was about sending a message. Not just to Dago, but to his brother, and to anyone else who thought they could use me as a stepping stone. They wanted a war? They were about to get one.

About a week after the attempted hit, my best friend, Boss Lady, and her old man, Dirtbag, met me at the Dollar General on Massey Tompkins. After the beating, the chain on my bike and the rear wheel were loose, and the chain was dragging against

the frame. Dirtbag, bless his mechanical soul, was going to help me get it lined up and tight again.

The three of us were standing around the bike, talking shop, when Dago walks up.

The nerve of this guy, strolling up bold as brass. He looks at my bike, then looks at me, and says, "Hey, let me do a burnout on your bike".

I just kind of stared at him like he was retarded. In the world of bikes, people don't do that. It's like walking up to you and saying, "Hey, man, let me fuck your ole lady." No, in fact, we're fixing to have problems.

This time, I straighten up. My body is still aching, but the adrenaline is kicking in.

"Dude," I say, my voice low and firm, "I don't know who the fuck you think you're talking to but you need to move around."

He ignored me, completely. Dago just

starts telling this story about how he had an opportunity to have a bike just like this a few nights back but he fucked up the job and then he just turned and walked away. I wasn't really paying much attention to the story Dago was telling. My mind was still reeling from the past week, planning my next moves, trying to figure out how to get my phone back and what Chris Johnson was doing. It wasn't until later, after Dago had left, that Boss Lady nudged me.

"Mr. Easton," she said, her voice serious, "Did you hear that story?"

"No, why?" I grunted, still distracted.

She repeated the story, word for word.

Every detail. And as she spoke, the pieces clicked into place. The casual mention of "a bike just like this," the way he'd fucked up the job "a few nights back." It suddenly hit me, like a physical blow. The blood

started to boil in my veins. That big son of a bitch. That cocky motherfucker. He wasn't just admitting it. He was bragging about it.

That was the man. I called in my whole crew and gave them the info that would lead me to this guy. The problem was he was a ghost. No one knew him or had ever seen him. I applied all sorts of tactics from bribery to beatings but no one knew anything. I searched for weeks and months for that Fucktard but even now 10 years later and over a 1000 miles away I'm waiting for one of my family to call me up and say we found him.

I wish I could tell you that was the only time bad shit happened to me but this ain't Disney and in Baytown and the East Side shit ain't easy if you're trying to be the man and thanks to one of my street brothers

(Sammy) I've been introduced to someone really making things shake. Him and Sammy grew up together and so when Sammy tells him hey T. this is Mr. Easton he's like my brother just like you are and if you would treat him like you would me I would really appreciate it.

Meeting T.

T. looked me up and down, sizing me up the way dealers do when they're deciding if you're worth their time or if you're gonna be a problem. He was older than Sammy and me, maybe mid-thirties, with the kind of weathered face that comes from years of staying awake when the sun goes down. His eyes were sharp, calculating. This wasn't some corner boy slinging dime bags. This was business.

"Sammy says you're good people," T. said,

extending his hand. "Says you move weight and you don't bring heat."

I shook his hand, firm grip, looking him straight in the eye. In this game, respect is everything, and it starts with how you carry yourself in that first meeting. "Sammy don't lie," I said. "I'm looking to expand my operation. Need a reliable connect who can handle volume."

T. nodded slow, like he was processing something. "Volume, huh? What kind of numbers we talking about?"

Now here's the thing about moving up in the game - you can't show all your cards at once, but you also can't play small ball when opportunity knocks. I'd been building my client base for months, carefully, methodically. The beating from Dago had

actually worked in my favor in some twisted way. Word on the street was that I'd been jumped and robbed but kept my mouth shut, didn't snitch, didn't run crying to nobody. That kind of reputation opens doors.

"Let's just say I'm not looking for personal use quantities," I told him. "My phone don't stop ringing, and I'm tired of having to tell people I'm out."

T. cracked a smile at that. "Man after my own heart. I hate disappointed customers." He lit up a cigarette and took a long drag. "Tell you what. Sammy vouches for you, that carries weight with me. But I don't know you from Adam's house cat. So we start small, see how it goes."

The next few weeks were like a dance. T.

would call, I'd meet him at different spots around town - sometimes the Whataburger on Garth Road, sometimes the parking lot behind the old Montgomery Ward, once at the boat launch near the bay. Each time, the quantity got a little bigger, the trust grew a little stronger. My phone was ringing off the hook, and for the first time since I'd started dealing, I wasn't scrambling to re-up every few days.

What I didn't know at the time was that T. was moving about 40 tons of meth a month through his well-connected network. He wasn't cartel himself, but he had serious connections that let him operate on a massive scale. T. made two pickups a month, both of them coordinated through his network that reached all the way back to the source. Baytown sat right on the gulf, which made

it a strategic location for moving product in and out.

Over the course of a few months, T. and I became really close. The man had been arrested 26 times in the course of a month, and the only person who had been there for him was me. Every time he got locked up, I was there to bond him out. No questions asked, no hesitation. That kind of loyalty meant everything in this business.

One night, T. came over to me and Raindrop's RV. Raindrop was this laid-back gurl I'd gotten lucky with - she wasn't trying to get into nobody's business, just stayed in her lane and kept things peaceful. But T. had something serious on his mind.

"Easton," T. said, settling into the cramped space of our RV, his eyes more serious than I'd ever seen them. "I've been thinking about what you've done for me. Twenty-six times, man. Twenty-six times you've been there when nobody else would even answer the phone."

I shrugged. "That's what family does."

"Exactly," he said, leaning forward. "And that's why I'm gonna bring you into the big leagues. Tomorrow morning, you're going with me to make a pickup."

That's when Raindrop, who had been quietly listening from the kitchenette, reached forward and put her hand over mine. She looked at me, then turned and looked at T.

"With all due respect, sir," she said, her voice calm but firm, "my boyfriend's not going anywhere with you tomorrow."

T. was just flabbergasted. As was I. I had never seen Raindrop act in such a manner. She was always so laid back, never got involved in business, never spoke up against anybody. But here she was, staring down a man who moved 40 tons a month.

T. and I continued to talk for a while after that. He laid out some information that I tucked away for later, details about how the operation worked, who the players were, what kind of money we were talking about. The conversation took a turn when T. pulled out a 9 millimeter Beretta.

"This piece was used in a homicide in Galveston County on New Year's 2013," T.

said, his voice matter-of-fact. "Killed two black men. I need you to dispose of the weapon."

I looked at the gun in his hands, understanding exactly what this meant. This wasn't just about trust anymore. This was about making me complicit, giving me skin in the game that went way beyond dealing dope.

"Yeah," I said, taking the Beretta. "Sure. No problem."

Even after Raindrop stopped the big connect from happening, T. and I kept building our relationship. The trust was there, the respect was there, and the business kept flowing. That's when Tony Davis came into the picture.

Tony Davis and the Road to Mobile

Tony Davis came from Mobile, Alabama without knowing ANYONE in Baytown. He'd heard Baytown was the place to be - sitting right on the gulf meant better quality, better prices, and connections that ran deep. Tony was looking for a plug, someone who could set him up right.

Tony wound up meeting lil C through two guys - Max and Tracy - who knew lil C and started making small runs for him. But while Tony was working these small jobs, he kept hearing the same things over and over:

"Mr. Easton has the best dope around."

"Mr. Easton has the cheapest dope around."

"Mr. Easton will take it wherever you need it to go."

My name was becoming legendary on the streets, and Tony decided that's who he needed to meet. He set about trying to get someone to tell him where I lived or give him my phone number. But nobody would give up the info. Max and Tracy didn't even know me. Meanwhile, I kept hearing about this guy from Alabama causing trouble, and I decided to deal with it head-on.

Tony got frustrated and sent his lackies to "persuade" someone to give them my number. They failed and reported back to him at Big Sexy's apartment. When they finished their report, Tony slowly took his belt off and stared them both down.

"Do you know what failure means for you?" he asked, his voice cold.

They responded in turn, "Please boss, give

us another chance. We won't fail again."

As the last words fell from their lips, Tony lunged and swung hard with the belt. He connected and didn't stop till they looked more elephant-like than man-like, swollen and beaten beyond recognition. When he was done, he said it like he knew he was cursed.

Ten days went by, and Tony got a call from home saying his uncle died. Him and Mindi jumped in his old car and shagged ass back to Mobile for the funeral. During the funeral is when I finally got his number and called him.

Tony answered his phone, probably not expecting what came next.

"I hear you been looking for me," I said,

"and beat them 2 boys because they couldn't find me for you. My people give me their loyalty because I'm there for them always."

I told Tony he didn't have to wonder where I was and provided an address. Tony explained what was going on and where he was - at his uncle's funeral. I gave my respect, condolences, and apologized for the timing. Tony told me we could still deal with each other when he got back from Alabama.

When Tony got back to Baytown, he told his 2 lackies - Max and Tracy - that the three of them were gonna jump me. How dare I try and make Tony look weak, right? He then called me and set up a peaceful meet at the Econo Inn & Suites of Baytown on Alexander that has a bar and grill too.

But I'm super paranoid, always have been. I decided to scope out the scene early and caught them sitting in a car in an empty parking lot, watching for me. I could see them plotting how best to roll me.

I tapped on the driver's front window with my "Easton" baseball bat. Everyone jumped and turned towards me. Once I had all of their full attention, I told the lackies to move around and looked at Tony.

"Do you know who the fuck I am?" I said, my voice low and dangerous. "You think I'm gonna let some fucking dumb ass from outta state come in and just take some of my shit?" I leaned closer to the window.

"Son, you musta lost you're FUCKING MIND!!!"

That's when my phone rang. It was a gurl who was lil C's roommate. She said there were 2 males and a female stealing lil C's everystuff.

I looked at Tony and told him, "We have 2 choices. We deal with our BS and then I'll go deal with this new sit, or 2, we put our shit to the side and go save our boy's shit."

In the game, you never show weakness, never show doubt. I wasn't about to let Tony think I needed his help - I was doing him a favor by letting him come along.

Very few have ever seen me fight, and those are usually the ones I was fighting. Tony quickly decided it was best to help me. Besides, lil C was kinda his friend.

We pulled up at lil C's house and I was

stepping out with my baseball bat before the car was fully stopped. I swung the bat and smashed the left headlight. I was on a full-blown fucking something off tantrum. As I beat one guy, the 2nd guy rushed me, thinking he had an advantage. I easily got outta the way and delivered a short uppercut to his eye socket. If the blow had been any heavier, the guy would've needed plastic surgery.

Then Ashley - lil C's ex - came hauling ass outta the house, arms loaded with lil C's baseball and basketball memorabilia. She stopped and said, "What the fuck is wrong with you guys? Ur attacking us at my house."

"Ashley," I said, my voice steady, "1st you should pay attention to who ur talking to. I know yall broke up a week ago and even if

yall hadn't of broken up, NO WAY he would have told you to take ANYTHING from his house so fuck off before u meet my buddy lil Easton." I tapped the bat against my palm.

During this time, Tony had retrieved the stuff they had managed to stuff in the truck.

That afternoon, 2 things happened. First, I changed my mind about taking Tony out for TRYING TO plot against me. The 2nd thing was I had purchased lil C's loyalty for life by risking my well being to save his stuff and not take advantage of him.

This ain't Disney, like I said. And in Baytown, on the East Side, when you're trying to be the man, sometimes the man comes with blood on his hands.

PART TWO: The Mobile Connection

Chapter 1: Building Trust

After the showdown at lil C's house, Tony and I drove to a Whataburger on Garth Road. The adrenaline was still pumping through my veins, making my hands shake - though that could've also been my blood sugar dropping again. I ordered two honey butter chicken biscuits and a Dr Pepper, shotgunning the soda before the food even arrived.

Tony sat across from me in the booth, studying me like I was some kind of puzzle he couldn't quite figure out. His two lackies, Max and Tracy, had taken off in their own vehicle, probably to lick their wounds and reconsider their life choices. "You're different than what I expected," Tony finally said, breaking the silence between us.

"Yeah? What'd you expect?" I asked, tearing into my first biscuit.

"Someone more..." he paused, searching for the word, "predictable. Most dealers I know, they're either all business or all violence. You switch between them like flipping a light switch."

I swallowed and leaned back. "That's because most dealers you know are idiots. They think this game is about being the hardest, the meanest, the most feared. That's amateur shit. The real game is about being unpredictable. You keep people guessing, they can't plot on you as easy."

Tony nodded slowly, a smile creeping across his face. "That's exactly why I need to work with you. Mobile's got product, but it's got too many people trying to run the same play. Everything's predictable. Police know every move before it happens."

"What kind of volume you moving back home?" I asked.

"Was doing about five pounds a week before I came out here. Had a solid customer base, but the heat was getting too close. My cousin got popped, and I knew it was only a matter of time before they came knocking on my door."

Five pounds a week. That was respectable, but not huge. Still, it showed Tony knew how to move product and keep customers happy. And more importantly, he had connections back in Alabama that could be useful.

"Here's what I'm thinking," I said, leaning forward. "You know people back in Mobile who need quality product at good prices. I got access through T. to more product than God. We set up a pipeline - you make runs back to Alabama once a month, move serious weight, come back here to re-up."

You make your money, I make my money, everybody's happy."

"What's the split?" Tony asked, his business mind clearly engaged now.

"Depends on the quantity. You moving five pounds, I'll give you a rate that lets you double your money back home. You moving ten, fifteen pounds, the rate gets even better. The more you move, the better we both do."

Tony's eyes lit up. This was the opportunity he'd been looking for. "When can we start?"

"Soon as you're ready. But first, we need to settle this other bullshit between us."

Tony shifted uncomfortably. "Look, man, I know I came at you wrong. I was frustrated, acting on bad information. That shit with Max and Tracy..." he trailed off.

"You beat them boys bloody because they couldn't get my number," I said flatly. "That

tells me you got a temper problem. That tells me you might do something stupid when things don't go your way."

"I won't lie - I do have a temper. But I'm working on it. And after seeing how you handled tonight, I got a lot more respect for how you operate. You didn't have to let me come along to lil C's. You could've just dealt with me right there in that parking lot."

"Yeah, I could have. But that would've been stupid. You see, violence is a tool, not a solution. I use it when I need to, but I don't rely on it. Because the moment you rely on violence, you become predictable again."

We talked for another hour, laying out the basics of how our partnership would work. By the time we left Whataburger, we had an understanding. Tony would make his first run back to Mobile in two weeks, taking ten pounds with him. If all went

well, we'd scale up from there.

Chapter 2: The Setup

The two weeks flew by in a blur of activity. I had to coordinate with T. to make sure I could get the quantity I needed without disrupting my regular business. That meant keeping all my local clients happy while also stashing enough product for Tony's Alabama run.

During this time, I also had to deal with the ongoing situation with Dago. Word on the street was that his brother, the Hells Angel, was asking questions about me.

Apparently, Dago had failed to kill me like he was supposed to, and now the club was wondering if he had what it took to wear their colors. Some of my people heard rumors that they might send someone else to finish what Dago started.

I wasn't about to sit around waiting for that to happen.

One afternoon, I was at J.D.'s working on my bike when lil C pulled up with information. He'd been working his contacts hard, trying to find anything that would lead us to Dago.

"Got something," lil C said, hopping out of his car with that characteristic swagger.

"One of my boys saw Dago hanging around a chop shop on the north side. Place called Martinez Auto. They move stolen bikes and cars through there."

"That's not surprising," J.D. chimed in, not looking up from the chain he was adjusting. "Half the stolen bikes in Baytown end up at Martinez at some point."

"Yeah, but here's the interesting part," lil C continued. "My boy says Dago's not just a customer. He's working there, helping move the stolen shit. Which means he's there regular, probably has a schedule."

I stood up from the bike, my mind already working through the possibilities. "We need eyes on that place. I want to know when he's there, who he's with, what kind of security they got."

"Already on it," lil C said with a grin. "Got two guys watching the place in shifts. Should have a pattern worked out in a few days."

"Good. Keep me posted."

As lil C drove off, J.D. finally looked up at me. "You sure you want to go after this guy? His brother's connected. You start a war with the Hells Angels, that's not something that ends well for anybody."

"I'm not starting a war," I said calmly. "I'm finishing one. Dago started this when he jumped me. His brother backed it when he promised him colors for killing me. This ain't about pride, J.D. This is about survival. If I let this slide, every wannabe

tough guy in Baytown is gonna think I'm soft. Then I'm done."

J.D. nodded slowly. He understood the game as well as I did. In this business, reputation was everything. You couldn't afford to let disrespect go unanswered. Two days before Tony was scheduled to make his Mobile run, T. called me with an urgent request to meet. We set up at our usual spot - the boat launch near the bay, late at night when nobody else would be around.

T. was already there when I arrived, leaning against his truck, smoking a cigarette. He looked stressed, which was unusual for him. T. always maintained a cool, calm demeanor no matter what was happening. "We got a problem," he said as soon as I walked up.

"What kind of problem?"

"The kind that could shut down everything if we don't handle it right." He took a long drag on his cigarette. "Remember those 26 arrests I told you about? Well, the DA's office has been building a case. They're trying to prove I'm running a distribution network. They don't have enough to make charges stick yet, but they're getting close." My stomach dropped. If T. went down, my whole supply chain collapsed. Everything I'd been building, all the connections I'd made, the partnership with Tony - it would all disappear overnight.

"How close are they?" I asked.

"Close enough that I need to lay low for a while. Maybe a few months. Which means I can't make my regular pickups, can't do the usual meets. I need someone I trust to handle things while the heat dies down."

"You want me to step up?"

T. looked at me hard, his eyes searching

mine for any sign of weakness or doubt. "This is big league shit, Easton. Not just moving a few pounds here and there. I'm talking about maintaining relationships with people who don't fuck around. You mess up, you don't get a second chance. They'll kill you and move on to the next guy without blinking."

I met his gaze without flinching. "I've been ready for this. You know I have. Every time you got locked up, who bonded you out? When you needed someone reliable, who did you turn to? I've proven myself."

T. smiled, but it didn't reach his eyes.

"Yeah, you have. That's why I'm offering this to you instead of anyone else. But I need you to understand what you're getting into. This ain't just about moving product. It's about managing people, handling problems, keeping law enforcement off your back. It's about

making hard decisions that could cost people their lives."

"I understand."

"Do you?" T. dropped his cigarette and ground it out with his boot. "Because once you step into this role, there's no going back. You become a target. Every dealer who wants to move up, every cop who wants to make a name for themselves, every rival crew looking to expand - they all come after you. Your life expectancy drops to about five years if you're lucky."

"Then I better make those five years count," I said.

T. studied me for another long moment, then nodded. "Alright. Here's how this is gonna work..."

Chapter 3: First Major Move

T. spent the next two hours walking me through everything I needed to know. He gave me contact information for his

suppliers, explained the pickup procedures, laid out the security protocols. By the time we finished, my head was spinning with information, but I understood what needed to be done.

The first pickup was scheduled for three days away - the day after Tony was supposed to leave for Mobile. T. would make the introduction to his main contact, a guy named Flaco who operated out of Houston, then step back and let me handle it from there.

"One more thing," T. said as we were wrapping up. "Flaco's gonna test you. He does it with everyone new. He'll try to rip you off, short you on weight or quality, see if you notice. You let it slide even once, he'll keep doing it and eventually cut you out completely. But you come at him wrong, accuse him without proof, he'll shut you down and you'll never work with him

again."

"So what do I do?"

"You be smart. You check everything carefully, document what you get, and if there's a problem, you handle it professionally. No threats, no drama. Just business. Flaco respects people who know their shit and don't get emotional."

I drove home that night feeling the weight of what I'd just taken on. This was what I'd been working toward since I started dealing, but now that it was here, the reality of it was sobering. One mistake could cost me everything - my freedom, my life, the lives of people who depended on me.

When I got back to the RV, Raindrop was still awake, reading a book by the small lamp over our bed. She looked up as I came in, and I could see the question in her eyes.

"T.'s laying low for a while," I told her. "He's putting me in charge of things while he's gone."

Raindrop closed her book slowly. "This is what you wanted, isn't it?"

"Yeah."

"Then why do you look like someone just told you your dog died?"

I sat down on the edge of the bed, suddenly exhausted. "Because I just realized that wanting something and being ready for it are two different things."

She reached over and put her hand on my arm. "You're ready. You've been ready. You're smart, you're careful, and you actually give a damn about the people working with you. That's more than most people in this business can say."

"People are gonna die, Raindrop. Maybe not tomorrow, maybe not next week, but eventually, someone's gonna die because

of decisions I make."

"People were already dying," she said softly. "That's the business you're in. The only question is whether you're gonna let that fact paralyze you or whether you're gonna do everything you can to minimize the damage while you're on top."

I looked at her, this woman who had somehow become my anchor in the chaos of my life. "How'd you get so wise?"

"I pay attention," she said with a slight smile. "Now come to bed. You've got a big few days ahead of you."

The next morning, I met with Tony to go over the final details of his Mobile run. We met at the same Econo Inn where we'd almost come to blows weeks earlier. This time, the energy was completely different - we were partners now, working toward the same goal.

I handed Tony a duffel bag containing ten

carefully packaged pounds of high-quality meth. "Your investment's about \$80,000," I told him. "You should be able to move this for around \$160,000 back in Mobile, maybe more depending on your prices. Half that profit is mine."

Tony nodded, understanding the terms we'd already agreed to. "I've got buyers lined up. Should have everything moved within a week, maybe less."

"Good. But here's the thing - you can't rush this. You take your time, you be careful, you don't do anything that might draw attention. I'd rather you take two weeks and do it right than one week and get popped."

"I understand."

"Do you?" I locked eyes with him. "Because this is more than just your freedom on the line now. You get caught, and you're carrying enough to put you away for life."

But that's not even the worst part. You get caught, and whoever you flip on comes after me. Then I gotta deal with that situation, which means people start dying. So when I say be careful, I mean treat this shit like your life depends on it - because it does."

Tony's expression got serious. "I won't let you down, Easton. You took a chance on me when you could've just dealt with me that first night. I don't forget that kind of loyalty."

We spent another hour going over routes, timing, communication protocols. Tony would drive straight through to Mobile, about nine hours with stops. He'd check in with me at predetermined times using burner phones. If anything went wrong, we had code words to indicate different types of problems.

As Tony was getting ready to leave, he

turned back to me. "One more thing. I heard some talk back in Mobile about a guy looking for a connect in Texas. Big buyer, moves serious weight across the Southeast. Might be worth exploring once I get this first run done."

"Let's focus on this one first," I said. "But yeah, keep your ears open. Always looking for good opportunities."

I watched Tony drive away, the duffel bag hidden in a custom compartment in his trunk. Everything was set up as well as it could be, but I couldn't shake the nervous feeling in my gut. This was a crucial moment - if Tony's run went smoothly, it opened up a whole new revenue stream. If it went bad, I'd lost \$80,000 and potentially gained a new enemy.

The next day was my meeting with Flaco. T. had arranged for us to meet at a warehouse in Houston's East End, in an

industrial area where nobody paid attention to people coming and going. I brought J.D. with me as backup, leaving him in the car with instructions to call for help if I wasn't out in thirty minutes.

The warehouse was exactly what you'd expect - concrete floors, high ceilings, the smell of motor oil and metal. Flaco was waiting inside with two of his guys, both of them big and mean-looking. Flaco himself was shorter, maybe 5'6", but he carried himself with the confidence of someone who'd been in the game a long time.

"So you're Easton," Flaco said, looking me up and down. "T. speaks highly of you."

"T.'s good people," I replied, keeping my tone neutral but respectful.

"He tell you how this works?"

"He gave me the basics."

Flaco smiled, but it wasn't friendly. "The basics. Sure. Let me give you the real

basics. I provide product, you provide money. You're always on time, you always take what you say you're gonna take, and you never, ever short me. You do those three things, we'll get along fine. You fuck up any of those three things, and we're done. Permanently."

"That's fair."

"Good. Because T.'s my boy, but that don't mean you get a pass if you screw up. I don't care how many times you bailed him out of jail."

So Flaco knew about that. Which meant he'd done his homework on me, knew my history with T. That was both good and bad - good because it meant he took me seriously, bad because it meant he'd be watching for any weakness.

"When's your first pickup?" Flaco asked.

"I was thinking end of the week."

"You were thinking," Flaco repeated, his

tone mocking. "Let me tell you something about thinking in this business - it gets you killed. You don't think, you plan. You don't guess, you confirm. You don't hope, you execute. So let's try this again. When's your first pickup?"

I took a breath, recognizing this for what it was - the test T. had warned me about.

"Friday night, 11 PM. I'll take twenty pounds to start, payment on delivery. After the first transaction, we can discuss credit terms for future deals."

Flaco's expression didn't change, but I caught a slight nod, like I'd passed some invisible evaluation. "Twenty pounds, Friday at 11. Cash only for the first three transactions. After that, we'll talk about credit if you've proven yourself reliable."

"What's the price per pound?"

"\$1,500."

I kept my face neutral, but my mind was

racing. T. had told me Flaco's usual price was \$1,200 per pound. The extra \$300 was the test - Flaco was inflating the price to see if I'd notice and, more importantly, to see how I'd handle it.

"That's higher than I was expecting," I said carefully. "Market rate's usually around \$1,200."

"Market rate's for people buying in small quantities. You want volume, you pay a premium for reliability and quality."

"I'm not arguing about quality," I said. "T. tells me you got the best product in Houston. But \$1,500's eating into my profit margins pretty heavy. Any flexibility there?" Flaco stared at me for a long moment, and I could feel his guys tensing up, ready for whatever came next. Then he laughed, a genuine sound that echoed through the warehouse.

"You got balls, I'll give you that. Most

people, they either don't notice or they're too scared to say anything." He waved his hand dismissively. "Fine. \$1,200 per pound, same as T. gets. But you better be worth it." "I will be."

We hammered out the rest of the details - payment procedures, quality guarantees, what happens if there's a problem with the product. By the time I left the warehouse, I felt like I'd just survived a prize fight. Every word, every gesture had been analyzed and judged.

J.D. looked relieved when I got back to the car. "How'd it go?"

"Better than expected," I said, pulling out of the parking lot. "Got the price I needed, established some boundaries. Now I just gotta deliver on Friday."

"You sure you're ready for this, Easton?"

I thought about Raindrop's words from the

night before, about being ready versus wanting something. "Ready or not, I'm in it now. Might as well make it count."

Chapter 4: The Alabama Connection

Tony called me two days into his Mobile run, right on schedule. He used our agreed-upon code phrases to let me know everything was going smoothly - "visiting family" meant he'd arrived safely, "catching up with old friends" meant he'd made contact with his buyers.

By day four, Tony called again with better news. "All the family business is wrapped up," he said, which meant he'd moved all ten pounds and collected payment. "Made some good connections too. That thing I mentioned before? The big buyer? He wants to meet."

"Tell me about him," I said, keeping my tone casual in case anyone was listening.

"Goes by Ray. Moves product from Texas

through Alabama, Mississippi, Louisiana, and into Florida. Big network, very professional. He's interested in setting up a direct line to Texas, cutting out some of his middlemen."

This was interesting. A buyer with that kind of reach could move serious volume, which meant serious money. But it also meant serious risk. The bigger the operation, the more likely law enforcement was watching.

"What's he looking for?"

"Started talking about fifty pounds a month, maybe more if things go well. He's willing to pay premium prices for reliability and quality."

Fifty pounds a month. That was \$60,000 in revenue for me at cost, potentially \$120,000 or more in profit depending on what Ray was willing to pay. It would also mean expanding my operation

significantly, which meant more risk.

"Tell him I'm interested in talking," I said.

"But not over the phone, and not until you're back in Texas. Face-to-face only."

"That's what I told him. He's actually coming through Houston next week on other business. Wants to set up a meeting."

"Alright. Come back, we'll settle up, and then we'll figure out the Ray situation."

Tony arrived back in Baytown three days later, pulling up to our meeting spot with a smile on his face and a backpack full of cash. We counted it together in the back of my truck - \$80,000 profit, split down the middle. Forty thousand each from one week's work.

"This is just the beginning," Tony said as we finished counting. "I got people in Mobile asking when I'm coming back, wanting to place orders. And Ray's serious about that fifty pounds a month. This

could be huge."

"Let's not get ahead of ourselves," I cautioned. "First, I gotta make sure I can supply that kind of volume consistently. I got my first pickup with Flaco tonight. Let's see how that goes before we start making promises we can't keep."

But internally, I was already planning. If I could secure Flaco as a reliable supplier and Tony could handle the Alabama distribution, we'd have a pipeline that would put me in the big leagues. Not T.'s level yet, but well on my way.

That night, I met Flaco at the warehouse with \$24,000 in cash and a nervous energy I was trying hard to hide. This was my first major pickup without T. running interference. Everything had to go perfectly. Flaco was already there when I arrived, along with his two guys and twenty

pounds of product laid out on a table. I'd brought a small digital scale and testing kit - tools I'd invested in specifically for this moment.

"You don't trust me?" Flaco asked when he saw me unpacking the scale.

"It's not about trust," I said evenly. "It's about making sure we both know exactly what's changing hands. Protects both of us if there's ever a question."

Flaco considered this, then nodded.

"Smart. I like that."

I spent the next thirty minutes carefully weighing each package, spot-checking the quality. Everything was exactly as advertised - twenty pounds, high quality, properly packaged. I handed over the cash, Flaco's guy counted it, and just like that, I was officially in the big leagues.

"Same time next week?" Flaco asked as I was loading the product into my truck.

"Actually, I might need to increase my order. Got some new opportunities opening up."

"How much we talking?"

"Maybe thirty, forty pounds. Depends on how things develop over the next few days."

Flaco's eyebrows rose slightly. "You move fast, Easton. Just make sure you're not moving too fast. Lot of people crash and burn trying to expand before they're ready."

"I'm ready," I said with more confidence than I felt.

As I drove away from the warehouse, my truck loaded with product worth over \$100,000 on the street, the reality of my new position hit me. I was now responsible for a quarter million dollars in inventory and cash flow every month, with plans to double that. I had people depending on me - Tony, my regular

clients, the crew I'd built up. And I had enemies watching, waiting for me to slip up.

Dago and his Hells Angels connection were still out there somewhere. The cops were always circling. And now I had the added pressure of maintaining relationships with serious players like Flaco and potentially Ray.

I called Raindrop. "Hey babe, I'm gonna be late tonight. Gotta make some drops."

"Be careful," she said, like she always did.

"Always am."

But as I hung up the phone and headed toward my first delivery, I couldn't help but think about T.'s warning - five years if I was lucky. The clock was already ticking.

Chapter 5: Ray's Proposition

The meeting with Ray was set up at a neutral location - a BBQ restaurant off

Highway 59 in Humble, far enough from both Houston and Baytown that neither of us had home field advantage. Tony came with me, along with J.D. for security. Ray brought two of his own people, both of them wearing the kind of casual but expensive clothes that said money without screaming it.

Ray himself was not what I expected. Mid-forties, clean-cut, looked more like a real estate agent than a major drug trafficker. He had an easy smile and a firm handshake, the kind of guy who could blend into any room without raising suspicion.

"Mr. Easton," he said warmly. "Tony's told me a lot about you. Says you're the most reliable connect he's ever worked with."

"Tony tends to exaggerate," I replied, "but I appreciate the sentiment. He tells me you're looking to establish a regular supply

line."

"Straight to business. I like that." Ray gestured to the table. "Let's sit, order some food, and talk about how we can help each other."

Over brisket and ribs, Ray laid out his operation. He had a network of distributors across four states, moving product through a combination of semi-trucks, personal vehicles, and even some small aircraft. His current Texas connection was reliable but expensive, and the quality had been slipping lately.

"I need someone who can provide consistent quality at a reasonable price," Ray explained. "Tony says you can do fifty pounds a month, maybe more. That true?"

"Depends on the price point," I said. "I can get quantity, but I need to make sure the margins work for everyone."

"I'm paying \$2,800 per pound right now.

I'm willing to go to \$2,500 with the right partner, someone who can guarantee quality and delivery."

I did the math in my head. I was paying Flaco \$1,200 per pound, which meant \$1,300 profit per pound. On fifty pounds, that was \$65,000 profit per month, on top of what I was already making from my local business and Tony's Mobile runs. The numbers were staggering.

But the risk was also staggering. Moving fifty pounds a month to one buyer meant putting all my eggs in one basket. If Ray got popped, or if he decided to rob me, or if any number of things went wrong, I'd be looking at massive losses and potential legal exposure.

"\$2,500's a fair price," I said carefully. "But I need some assurances. First, payment on delivery for the first three months. After that, we can talk about credit terms.

Second, you handle all transportation from the pickup point. I'll deliver to a location in Houston, but after that, it's your risk. Third, if there's ever a quality issue, you let me know immediately and I'll make it right."

Ray nodded along as I spoke. "Those terms work for me. What about delivery schedule?"

"First of the month, every month. You'll get a call forty-eight hours before with the exact time and location. You show up with cash, I show up with product, we make the exchange and go our separate ways."

"Simple. I like simple." Ray extended his hand across the table. "We got a deal." I shook his hand, sealing an agreement that would either make me rich or get me killed. Probably both.

After Ray and his people left, Tony, J.D., and I sat in my truck in the parking lot, processing what had just happened.

"You realize you just agreed to move fifty pounds a month to a guy you just met," J.D. said.

"I'm aware."

"And you're not worried that this might be a setup? That Ray might be law enforcement?"

"Of course I'm worried. But I did my homework. Tony's people in Mobile vouch for Ray, and I had lil C. make some calls to his contacts in Louisiana. Ray's legit - been in the game for over a decade, never been popped, runs a tight operation. If he was law enforcement, someone would've made him by now."

Tony spoke up. "Ray's solid, J.D. I wouldn't have brought this to Easton if I wasn't sure."

"Alright," J.D. said, though he still looked worried. "But we need to be extra careful with this. One mistake and we're all going

down."

He wasn't wrong. I was now juggling multiple major deals simultaneously - my local business, Tony's Mobile runs, and now Ray's fifty pounds a month. That meant I needed to increase my orders from Flaco significantly, which would make me a much bigger target for law enforcement.

The next day, I called Flaco to discuss increasing my regular orders. He agreed to meet at the warehouse that afternoon.

"Forty pounds a week," Flaco said, his eyebrows raised. "That's a big jump from twenty."

"I've got the buyers and the cash flow to support it. Question is, can you supply that consistently?"

"I can supply it. Question is, can you move it? Because if you start ordering forty and then can't move it, you're gonna have

product sitting around getting stale. That's bad for both of us."

"I can move it," I said confidently. "Got a new buyer out of Alabama, moves serious volume. Between him and my regular business, forty pounds a week is actually conservative."

Flaco studied me for a long moment.

"You're moving up fast, Easton. Real fast. That's good for business, but it also means you're gonna attract attention. Cops, competitors, jealous motherfuckers who want what you got. You ready for that?"

"I've been dealing with that since day one. Dago and his Hells Angels friend tried to take me out months ago. I'm still here."

"Dago?" Flaco's expression changed. "Little punk hangs around Martinez Auto?"

"You know him?"

"Know of him. He's been trying to move in

on some of my retailers, offering cheaper prices but shit quality. I've been meaning to have a conversation with him about that."

This was interesting. If Flaco had beef with Dago too, maybe we could solve both our problems at once.

"He jumped me back in July," I said. "Beat me pretty bad, stole my product and my bike keys. Been looking for him ever since." Flaco nodded slowly, a dangerous glint in his eye. "Maybe it's time we both had that conversation with him. You interested in a joint operation?"

"Depends on what you have in mind."

"Nothing too dramatic. Just a friendly chat about business practices and respect. Maybe remind him that there are consequences for stepping on the wrong toes."

I considered this carefully. Partnering with

Flaco to deal with Dago would solve my problem, but it would also put me deeper in Flaco's pocket. On the other hand, having Flaco as an ally instead of just a supplier could be valuable down the line. "Let's do it," I said. "But I want to be there when it happens. This is personal for me." "Wouldn't have it any other way."

Chapter 6: The Dago Solution

Lil C.'s surveillance had finally paid off. Dago was at Martinez Auto every Tuesday and Thursday afternoon, helping move stolen vehicles and parts. The shop was run by a guy named Martinez (creative name, I know) who had connections to several motorcycle clubs, including the Hells Angels chapter that Dago's brother belonged to.

The plan was simple - Flaco would show up at Martinez Auto with me and his guys, ostensibly to discuss business. Martinez

knew Flaco, had even moved some product for him in the past. We'd get inside, corner Dago, and have our "conversation."

Tuesday afternoon, I met Flaco and his crew at a gas station two miles from Martinez Auto. There were five of us total - Flaco, his two regular guys, me, and Rob. I'd brought Rob specifically because of his size and his willingness to get physical if needed. Plus, he was family, and I trusted him to have my back no matter what.

"Remember," Flaco said as we went over the plan one last time, "we're not there to start a war. We just want to send a message. We go in, we find Dago, we have a conversation. If he gets stupid, we handle it, but we keep it professional."

"Define professional," Rob rumbled.

"No killing, no permanent damage, nothing that's gonna bring heat down on all of us."

A beating's fine, but we're not cutting off fingers or shooting people."

I nodded my agreement. This wasn't about murder - it was about establishing dominance and getting answers. I wanted to know why Dago jumped me, who told him to do it, and what his brother's role was in all this.

We pulled up to Martinez Auto in two vehicles. The shop was a sprawling complex of garages and storage buildings, surrounded by a chain-link fence. Several motorcycles and cars in various states of disassembly were scattered around the property. A couple of guys were working on a chopper near the main garage.

Flaco walked up to the front office like he owned the place, and the rest of us followed. Martinez himself came out when he heard us enter - a heavyset man in his fifties with grease-stained hands and

suspicious eyes.

"Flaco," Martinez said warily. "Wasn't expecting you today."

"Impromptu visit," Flaco replied smoothly.

"Got some business to discuss. Dago around?"

Martinez's eyes flicked to me, and I could see him putting the pieces together. "Don't want no trouble in my shop, Flaco."

"No trouble. Just a conversation. Dago here or not?"

After a long pause, Martinez jerked his head toward the back. "In the storage building, inventorying some parts."

We walked through the main garage, past workers who suddenly found their work very interesting and avoided making eye contact. The storage building was a metal structure filled with shelves of automotive parts, both legitimate and definitely not legitimate.

Dago was in the back, clipboard in hand, counting spark plugs. He looked up when he heard us approaching, and the blood drained from his face when he saw me.

"Hey Dago," I said casually. "Remember me?"

He tried to run, but Rob had already moved to block the exit. Flaco's guys spread out, cutting off any other escape routes. Dago was trapped.

"Look, man," Dago stammered, "I was just following orders. My brother said-"

"Your brother said if you killed me, you could ride with the Hells Angels," I

interrupted. "Yeah, I heard. Question is, why me? What did I ever do to you?"

"You were moving in on territory my brother's chapter considers theirs. He wanted to send a message to anyone else thinking about expanding into Baytown without permission."

Flaco spoke up. "That's interesting, because I've been moving product through Baytown for five years and never had a problem with the Hells Angels. So either your brother's lying to you, or he's going rogue from his chapter."

Dago's expression shifted from fear to confusion. "What do you mean?"

"I mean," Flaco continued, walking closer to Dago, "that the Hells Angels don't give a shit about small-time dealers like Easton here. No offense, Easton."

"None taken."

"So if your brother told you to kill Easton to prove yourself, either he was lying about the club backing it, or he's running his own operation outside the club and using their name for leverage."

I could see Dago processing this information, realizing he might have been played. "But he said the club president

approved it..."

"Did you hear the president say it?" I asked.

"Or did you just take your brother's word for it?"

Silence.

"That's what I thought," I said. "So here's what's gonna happen. You're gonna tell me everything about your brother's operation - who he works with, where he keeps his product, what his plans are. Then you're gonna help me send him a message."

"I can't do that. He's my brother."

Rob stepped forward, cracking his knuckles. "You jumped Mr. Easton, beat him half to death, stole his shit, and left him for dead. Far as I'm concerned, you're lucky we're even giving you a choice."

"Wait, wait," Dago said quickly. "What kind of message?"

I smiled, but it wasn't friendly. "The kind that makes it clear that using me as a test

is bad for business. The kind that reminds him there are rules in this game, and he broke them."

Over the next hour, Dago spilled everything. His brother, who went by Reaper, was running a side operation separate from the Hells Angels chapter. He was using the club's reputation to intimidate smaller dealers into giving him territory or paying protection money. The club president didn't know about it, and if he found out, Reaper would be kicked out or worse.

Reaper kept his personal stash at a storage unit in La Porte, about fifteen miles south of Baytown. He made his collections every Friday night, usually alone or with just one other person. He thought his club affiliation made him untouchable.

He was about to learn otherwise.

"Here's the deal," I told Dago. "You're gonna set up your brother. Tell him you've got a big score lined up - a dealer who's ready to pay protection money to avoid problems. Tell him to meet you at that storage unit Friday night."

"He'll never believe I could land someone that big."

"Tell him it's me. Tell him you found out where I've been hiding since the attack, and you convinced me that paying protection is better than another beating. His ego won't let him resist."

Dago hesitated, and I could see the internal struggle playing out on his face. This was his brother, after all. But he'd also just learned that his brother had been manipulating him, using him as a pawn in a scheme that could get them both killed. "If I do this," Dago said slowly, "you gotta promise me something. When this is done,

we're even. No retaliation, no coming after me later. Clean slate."

I looked at Flaco, who shrugged. "Your call, Easton."

"Fine," I said. "You help us with Reaper, and we're done. But if you ever cross me again, if you ever even think about crossing me, there won't be a second conversation. We clear?"

"Crystal."

We let Dago go with instructions to set up the meeting with Reaper for Friday night. As we walked back through Martinez Auto, Flaco pulled me aside.

"You trust him to actually set this up?" he asked.

"Not even a little bit. But I've got lil C. watching him twenty-four seven between now and Friday. If he tries to warn his brother or run, we'll know."

"Good. Because I've got a lot riding on you,

Easton. This thing with Ray, the increased orders, all of it. I need to know you can handle problems when they come up."

"I can handle it."

"I hope so. Because if this Reaper situation goes sideways, it could bring heat down on all of us. The Hells Angels might not sanction what he's doing now, but if we take out one of their members, sanctioned or not, they're gonna have to respond."

I'd already thought about this, spent the last few hours running through scenarios.

"That's why we're not gonna kill him. We're just gonna make it very clear that he crossed the wrong people. Maybe take his product, maybe rough him up a bit. But we leave him alive and we make sure he knows that if he retaliates, we go to his club president with everything Dago just told us."

Flaco considered this, then nodded approvingly. "You're learning. Most people in your position, they'd want blood. But blood just creates more problems. Smart play is to neutralize the threat and leave yourself an out."

"T. taught me that," I said. "He said the best fight is the one you never have to have."

"T.'s a wise man. Shame he's gotta lay low for a while."

We split up, agreeing to meet again Friday night to deal with Reaper. As I drove back to Baytown with Rob, I felt the weight of everything I'd set in motion. In less than a week, I'd agreed to supply fifty pounds a month to Ray, increased my orders from Flaco to forty pounds a week, and set up an operation against a Hells Angels member.

"You good?" Rob asked, breaking the silence.

"Just thinking about how fast everything's moving."

"Too fast?"

"Maybe. But there's no slowing down now. We're committed."

Rob was quiet for a moment, then said, "You remember that time we almost killed each other? When we found out we were family?"

"Hard to forget."

"I think about that sometimes. How close we came to doing something we couldn't take back. And I think about how lucky we were that we found out the truth before it was too late." He looked over at me. "My point is, we're family, and family looks out for each other. So if you're getting in over your head, if you need to step back and reassess, I got your back. We all do."

"I appreciate that, Rob. But I'm not in over my head. I'm exactly where I need to be."

"Alright then. Just remember - being the man comes with a target on your back. T. knew that, which is why he's taking a break. Maybe you should think about having an exit plan, just in case."

He was right, of course. I was so focused on building the empire that I hadn't really thought about what happens if it all falls apart. T. had a backup plan, money stashed away, connections that could help him disappear if needed. I had none of that. "I'll work on it," I promised.

When I got back to the RV that night, Raindrop was waiting with dinner - chicken and rice, simple but filling. She could tell something was on my mind.

"Bad day?" she asked.

"Complicated day. Found Dago, set up a thing for Friday. Also agreed to a big deal that could change everything."

"Change it how?"

I told her about Ray and the fifty pounds a month, about the increased orders from Flaco, about the money that would be coming in. She listened without interrupting, her expression neutral.

When I finished, she said, "You're building something big. That's good. But big things fall hard when they fall. What happens if Ray gets arrested? Or if Flaco decides he'd rather cut you out and deal directly with your buyers?"

"I've thought about that-"

"Have you? Because it seems like you're thinking about the upside without really considering the downside. And in this business, the downside can get you killed or locked up for life."

"What do you want me to do, Raindrop? Turn down the opportunity? Play it safe and stay small?"

"I want you to be smart," she said, her voice rising. "I want you to think about what happens when - not if, but when - something goes wrong. Do you have money saved? Do you have a lawyer on retainer? Do you have an escape plan if the cops come knocking?"

I didn't have good answers to any of those questions, and we both knew it.

"I'll figure it out," I said lamely.

"You better. Because I love you, but I'm not gonna sit here and watch you throw your life away because you're too proud or too ambitious to see the danger."

We didn't talk much the rest of the night. I knew she was right, but I also knew there was no turning back now. I'd made commitments, shook hands on deals that couldn't be undone. All I could do was move forward and hope I was smart enough, fast enough, and lucky enough to

stay ahead of the consequences.

Chapter 7: Friday Night Reckoning

Friday came faster than I wanted. Lil C.

reported that Dago had followed through - he'd contacted his brother and set up the meeting at the storage unit for 10 PM.

Reaper had taken the bait, probably seeing it as an opportunity to finally establish dominance over me.

What he didn't know was that I wouldn't be alone.

We assembled at J.D.'s house around 8 PM - me, J.D., Rob, lil C., Big C., and Flaco with his two guys. Seven against two, assuming Reaper only brought one person like Dago said he would. The odds were in our favor, but that didn't mean things couldn't go sideways.

"Alright, listen up," I said, gathering everyone in J.D.'s garage. "This ain't about killing anybody. This is about sending a

message and getting my shit back.

Reaper's got my stolen property in that storage unit - my product from when Dago jumped me, maybe other stuff too. We go in, we neutralize them, we take what's mine, and we leave. Clean and simple."

"What if they're armed?" Big C. asked.

"Then we respond appropriately. But guns stay holstered unless they pull first. We want them scared, not dead."

Flaco added, "And remember, this guy's Hells Angels. We leave him alive but humiliated, word spreads that he's weak. That's worse than killing him, because it makes him look like a punk who couldn't handle business."

We loaded up and headed to La Porte. The storage facility was one of those big complexes with hundreds of units, individual garage-style doors with roll-up shutters. Security was minimal - a fence,

some cameras that probably didn't work, and a keypad entry system that we bypassed easily.

Reaper's unit was in the back corner, away from the main office and the few security lights. Perfect for someone storing illegal goods. We parked two streets over and walked in, staying in the shadows.

We got there early, setting up positions around the unit. Rob and Big C. hid behind a nearby dumpster. Lil C. and J.D.

positioned themselves between two units across the way. Flaco and his guys stayed with me near Reaper's unit door.

At 9:55 PM, headlights appeared. A big pickup truck with loud exhaust rolled into view, parking directly in front of the storage unit. Two men got out - Reaper, unmistakable in his leather vest with Hells Angels patches, and another biker, similarly dressed.

Reaper was huge, at least 6'4" and probably 280 pounds, most of it muscle. His friend wasn't much smaller. Both of them looked like they'd been in plenty of fights and won most of them.

"Where's your brother?" Reaper called out, looking around.

That was my cue. I stepped out of the shadows, bat in hand. "Dago ain't coming. But I am."

Reaper's face went from confusion to recognition to rage in about two seconds.

"You."

"Me. Surprise."

"You got some balls showing up here. You know who I am?"

"Yeah, I know. You're the guy who used his brother to jump me because you're too much of a pussy to handle your own business."

That did it. Reaper charged at me, moving

faster than a man his size should be able to. I barely got the bat up in time to block his first punch, and even then the impact rattled my arms.

But Reaper had forgotten he wasn't alone. Rob and Big C. emerged from their hiding spot, coming at him from the side. At the same time, Flaco's guys moved on Reaper's friend, tackling him to the ground before he could even think about helping. Reaper realized too late that he'd walked into a trap. He tried to back away, but I was already swinging. The bat connected with his ribs, and I heard something crack. He stumbled, and Rob was there, delivering a massive punch to his jaw that dropped him to one knee.

"You wanted a test?" I said, standing over him. "Here's your test. You survive the next five minutes without pissing yourself, maybe you get to keep your colors."

For the next few minutes, we worked Reaper over. Nothing permanent, nothing that would cripple him, but enough to make sure he'd remember this night every time he looked in a mirror for the next month. Rob and Big C. focused on body shots while I worked his legs with the bat. We didn't touch his face much - that was intentional. We wanted him recognizable when he crawled back to his club. His friend fared about the same. Flaco's guys were professionals, delivering precise strikes that maximized pain without causing serious injury. When we were done, both bikers were on the ground, conscious but barely. I knelt down next to Reaper.

"Here's how this works," I said quietly.

"You're gonna stop using your club's name to shake down dealers. You're gonna stop sending people after me. And you're

gonna tell anyone who asks that you fucked with the wrong guy and learned your lesson."

"Fuck you," Reaper spat, blood dripping from his mouth.

I grabbed his vest, pulling him closer.

"Option two is I go to your club president and tell him everything. How you've been running a side operation, how you used club resources for personal business, how you sent your little brother to kill someone without chapter approval. How you think that's gonna play out?"

Reaper's eyes widened. He knew that would be a death sentence.

"That's what I thought. So we got an understanding?"

He nodded weakly.

"Good. Now give me the keys to your storage unit."

He hesitated, and I pressed the bat

against his broken ribs. He gasped in pain and fumbled in his pocket, pulling out a key ring.

We opened the storage unit to find a treasure trove - dozens of pounds of meth, cash, stolen motorcycle parts, and in the back corner, my original dope and my boots from the night Dago jumped me.

"Lil C., Big C., load up everything," I instructed. "We're taking it all."

"That's my shit," Reaper protested weakly.

"Was your shit. Now it's mine. Call it reparations for the trouble you caused."

We loaded everything into our vehicles - had to make two trips to get it all. By the time we finished, Reaper and his friend had managed to crawl back to their truck but hadn't tried to leave or call for help.

They knew they were beaten.

As we prepared to leave, Flaco walked over to Reaper one last time. "One more

thing. You ever come at Easton again, you ever even think about retaliation, I find out. And when I find out, I don't just beat you. I destroy you. Your operation, your reputation, everything. We clear?"

Reaper nodded.

We left them there, broken and humiliated. The drive back to Baytown was quiet, everyone processing what had just happened. We'd crossed a line tonight, jumped a Hells Angels member and robbed him. Even if he deserved it, even if he'd been operating outside his club's authority, there could be consequences.

"Think he'll keep his mouth shut?" J.D. asked.

"He doesn't have a choice," I said. "He talks, his club finds out what he was really doing. His only play is to pretend this never happened and hope we do the same."

We split up the haul at J.D.'s house. The

product - about thirty pounds of decent quality meth - got divided based on who needed what for their operations. The cash, about \$15,000, got split evenly among everyone who'd participated. The stolen motorcycle parts went to lil C., who knew how to fence them. And I got my boots back, along with my original stolen dope, which was admittedly pretty degraded by now.

"Not bad for a night's work," Big C. said, counting his share of the cash.

"It's not over," I cautioned. "We need to stay alert for the next few weeks. If Reaper changes his mind, if he decides to come after us anyway, we need to be ready."

But the weeks passed without incident. Word filtered back through the streets that Reaper had "taken a fall" working on a motorcycle and was recovering from his injuries. Nobody questioned it, and more

importantly, nobody came looking for revenge.

The bigger change was in how people treated me. Word spread fast about what happened - maybe Reaper talked despite our warnings, maybe somebody else saw something, or maybe people just put the pieces together. Either way, my reputation took a major leap.

I wasn't just the reliable dealer with good product anymore. I was the guy who'd gone up against a Hells Angels member and won. I was the guy you didn't fuck with, the guy who had the connections and the crew to handle serious problems.

My phone started ringing even more than before. New clients, bigger orders, people from outside Baytown wanting to connect. The business was exploding, and I was struggling to keep up.

Chapter 8: The Ray Deal

The first delivery to Ray happened on a Wednesday night, two weeks after the Reaper situation. Tony and I drove to Houston with fifty pounds carefully hidden in a custom compartment in my truck. The meeting spot was a warehouse district near the port, the kind of place where trucks came and went at all hours and nobody paid attention.

Ray was already there when we arrived, along with three of his people and a black SUV. He greeted us warmly, like we were old friends meeting for drinks instead of criminals conducting a felony transaction. "Right on time," Ray said approvingly. "I like that."

"Punctuality's important in any business," I replied.

We conducted the exchange quickly and professionally - fifty pounds out of my truck, \$125,000 in cash into my truck.

Ray's guys checked the product quality while I counted the money. Everything matched up perfectly.

"This is good stuff," one of Ray's guys reported. "Better than what we've been getting."

Ray smiled. "See? I knew you were the right partner, Easton. When can we do this again?"

"Same time next month, unless you need something sooner."

"Next month works. Actually, I wanted to talk to you about potentially increasing the order. I've got buyers in Florida asking for more product. Could you handle seventy-five, maybe a hundred pounds a month?"

I kept my expression neutral, but inside I was calculating frantically. A hundred pounds a month would mean \$120,000 in profit for me. But it would also mean tying up huge amounts of capital and taking on

significantly more risk.

"Maybe," I said. "Give me a couple months to see how this current arrangement works, then we can talk about expanding."

"Fair enough. I'll be in touch."

As Tony and I drove back to Baytown, counting the cash multiple times just to make sure it was real, I couldn't help but feel like everything was coming together. The Reaper problem was solved, Ray was a solid buyer, Flaco was a reliable supplier, and money was flowing in faster than I could count it.

"We're really doing it," Tony said, his voice filled with excitement. "We're actually making it big."

"Don't jinx it," I said automatically.

But even I had to admit - things were going remarkably well. Too well, maybe. In my experience, when things went this smoothly, it usually meant the universe

was setting you up for a harder fall.

I got back to the RV around 2 AM to find Raindrop still awake, reading by lamplight.

"How'd it go?" she asked.

I pulled out a stack of cash and set it on the small table. "\$125,000. Minus Tony's cut and expenses, we're clearing about \$50,000 from this one deal."

Her eyes widened. "That's..."

"A lot, I know."

She set her book down and looked at me seriously. "This is your chance, Easton.

You've got money coming in, you've got a solid operation. Start putting some of this away. Get a lawyer on retainer. Set up an escape fund. Do the smart things I've been asking you to do."

She was right, and I knew it. I was so caught up in the rush of success that I'd been neglecting the basics of survival in this business.

"Okay," I agreed. "Tomorrow I'll start looking for a lawyer. And I'll open an account at a bank outside of Baytown, start stashing cash there."

"Not a bank," Raindrop corrected. "Banks have records, and records can be subpoenaed. You need a safe deposit box, or better yet, multiple safe deposit boxes at different locations under different names. Spread the risk."

"Where'd you learn all this?"

She gave me a sad smile. "My ex was in the game too. He didn't plan ahead. Now he's doing twenty years in federal prison, and I'm living in an RV because everything we had got seized by the government."

I'd never heard her talk about her past before. It explained a lot about why she was so insistent on planning for the worst.

"I'm sorry," I said.

"Don't be sorry. Just be smart. Learn from

other people's mistakes so you don't have to make them yourself."

The next day, I started implementing Raindrop's suggestions. I found a lawyer in Houston who specialized in drug cases - not cheap, but supposed to be the best. I paid him a \$10,000 retainer and made sure he understood I might need him on short notice.

I rented safe deposit boxes at banks in Houston, League City, and Beaumont. Each one got a portion of cash - my escape fund, as Raindrop called it. Money that nobody knew about except her and me, money that couldn't be traced or seized if everything went sideways.

I also started paying more attention to operational security. Burner phones that got switched out regularly. Different meeting locations for different clients. Varying my routes and timing. All the little

things that made it harder for law enforcement to establish a pattern.

T. checked in with me periodically, calling from different numbers to avoid creating a traceable record. He seemed pleased with how I was handling things in his absence.

"You're doing good, Easton," he said during one call. "Better than I expected, honestly. Word is you're making moves, establishing yourself."

"Couldn't have done it without you setting things up," I replied.

"Maybe. But you're the one who took the opportunity and ran with it. A lot of people would've gotten scared or gotten greedy and fucked it up. You're threading the needle."

"When you think you'll be ready to come back?"

"Few more months, probably. DA's case isn't going anywhere - they know I'm into

something, but they can't prove it. Eventually they'll have to shit or get off the pot." He paused. "When I do come back, we should talk about partnership. You've proven yourself, and I could use someone I trust watching things while I handle other business."

Partnership with T. would mean access to his entire network, not just Flaco. It would mean moving from big leagues to major leagues. It was exactly what I'd been working toward.

"I'd be interested in that conversation," I said.

After we hung up, I sat in the RV feeling like I was finally getting control of my life. Six months ago, I'd been a small-time dealer getting jumped on the side

Chapter 9: The Unraveling

Three months into the Ray deal, everything

seemed perfect. I was pulling in around \$200,000 a month in gross revenue, clearing about \$80,000 in profit after expenses and paying my crew. I had safe deposit boxes stuffed with cash, a lawyer on retainer, and a reputation that opened doors all over Southeast Texas.

Then Chris Johnson came back into my life.

Chris was one of those guys who'd been on the periphery of my operation since the beginning - not quite in the inner circle, but close enough to know how things worked. He'd done some small jobs for me, acted as a middleman for a few deals, nothing major. But Chris had a problem: he couldn't keep his mouth shut when he got high, which was pretty much always.

I was at J.D.'s house working on my bike when lil C. showed up looking worried.

"We got a problem," he said without

preamble. "Chris has been running his mouth at the Kick Back, telling anyone who'll listen about your operation. Talking about the Ray deal, the Reaper thing, how much money you're making."

My blood went cold. "How long has this been going on?"

"At least a week, maybe longer. My boy just heard about it last night and called me this morning."

The Kick Back was a local bar known for being a hangout for both dealers and undercovers. If Chris had been talking there, there was a good chance narcotics had heard every word.

"Where's Chris now?"

"That's the other problem. Nobody's seen him since yesterday afternoon. His phone's going straight to voicemail."

J.D. looked up from the bike. "You think he got picked up?"

"Or he realized he fucked up and went into hiding," lil C. suggested.

Either way, it was bad. If Chris got arrested and was looking at serious time, he'd flip in a heartbeat. He knew enough to cause serious damage - not everything, but enough. And if he was hiding, it meant he knew people were looking for him, which meant word was spreading about his loose lips.

I pulled out my phone and called Rob. "We got a situation. Chris Johnson's been talking. Need you to put the word out - anyone sees him, I want to know immediately. And make it clear he better show his face to explain himself before things get worse."

"On it," Rob said and hung up.

Next I called Tony. "Ray's next pickup is postponed. Tell him something came up, needs to be rescheduled. Don't give

details."

"What's going on?"

"Security issue. I'll explain later. Just make sure Ray understands this isn't about him, it's about me tightening things up on my end."

I spent the next two days on edge, waiting for either Chris to surface or cops to come knocking on my door. Neither happened. What did happen was worse.

Big C. called me on the third day. "You need to get to the hospital. Chris is there."

"What happened?"

"Somebody beat him half to death. Found him in an alley off Market Street. He's in ICU."

I met Big C. at the hospital, and we managed to slip into Chris's room during a shift change. He looked terrible - face swollen, jaw wired shut, bandages everywhere. One eye was completely

closed, the other barely open.

"Chris," I said quietly, leaning close to his bed. "Who did this?"

He tried to talk, but with his jaw wired, it came out as garbled mumbling. He grabbed a pen and notepad from the bedside table and wrote with shaky hands: "Reaper's guys. Said stay quiet."

My stomach dropped. Reaper had found out about Chris's loose talk and decided to handle it himself. Which meant Reaper was still operating, still had resources, and most importantly, was still watching my operation.

"Did you talk to the cops?" I asked.

Chris shook his head, then wrote: "Told them I don't remember. They don't believe me."

"Good. Keep it that way." I paused, trying to figure out how to phrase the next question.

"Chris, did you tell anyone at the

Kick Back about the Ray deal? About the amounts, the schedule, any of it?"

He hesitated, then wrote: "Some. Was high. Don't remember everything I said."

I wanted to be angry, wanted to rage at him for his stupidity. But looking at him lying there, beaten to the point where he could barely function, I mostly just felt tired.

"Alright. Here's what's gonna happen.

You're done working with me. When you get out of here, you leave Baytown. I don't care where you go, but you're gone. I'll give you \$5,000 to help you get started somewhere else, but that's it. We're done."

Chris's visible eye widened, and he started writing frantically: "Please, I need this. I got nowhere else."

"You should've thought of that before you ran your mouth. You put everyone at risk - me, Tony, J.D., all of us. You're lucky all

you got was a beating." I stood up to leave. "The \$5,000 offer stands, but only if you're gone within a week of getting out of here. Otherwise, you're on your own."

As Big C. and I left the hospital, he asked, "You really gonna let him walk away? After what he did?"

"What's the alternative? Beat him worse than Reaper's guys already did? Kill him? That brings more heat, more problems. Best case scenario is he takes the money and disappears. Worst case, he's too broken to work in this business anymore anyway."

"Reaper sending his guys after Chris means he's still operating," Big C. pointed out. "Thought you handled that situation."

"I thought I did too. But apparently breaking his ribs and taking his shit wasn't enough of a message."

I called an emergency meeting of my inner

circle - J.D., Rob, lil C., Big C., and Tony. We met at the RV, cramming seven people into a space meant for two.

"We got two problems," I started. "First, Chris has been running his mouth about our operation. We don't know exactly what he said or who heard it, but we have to assume the worst - that narcotics knows about the Ray deal, knows about our volume, maybe even knows about the Reaper situation."

"So what do we do?" Tony asked.

"We pause everything for at least a month. No major deals, no new clients, nothing that could be used as evidence if they're building a case. We go back to small-time until the heat dies down."

Tony looked pained. "Easton, I've got buyers in Mobile counting on me. If I disappear for a month, they'll find other suppliers."

"Better to lose business than lose your freedom," I said firmly. "This is non-negotiable. Everyone scales back, keeps their heads down, and we wait to see if anything comes of Chris's big mouth."

"What about the second problem?" Rob asked.

"Reaper. He's the one who sent guys after Chris, which means he's still operating and still has enough resources to make moves. We hurt him, but we didn't shut him down."

"So we finish the job," lil C. said. "Go after him again, harder this time."

"No," I said, surprising everyone. "That's exactly what he wants. He's trying to provoke us into making a move that'll bring heat down on all of us. We attacked him once and got away with it. We do it again, his club will have to respond whether they sanctioned his operation or

not. It becomes about respect and reputation."

"So we just let him get away with it?" Big C. asked incredulously.

"We let it go for now. We focus on keeping our operation secure, on making sure there's nothing for the cops to find if they come looking. Reaper's problem will solve itself eventually - either his club finds out what he's been doing and handles it internally, or he makes a move against us and we respond in self-defense. Either way, we don't start that fight."

Nobody looked happy about this decision, but they understood the logic. In this business, sometimes the smartest move is no move at all.

Over the next week, I systematically shut down the major parts of my operation. I called Ray and explained there were security concerns that needed to be

addressed before we could resume our arrangement. He wasn't happy, but he understood - in this business, security concerns were taken seriously.

I cut my orders from Flaco down to almost nothing, just enough to maintain my relationship with him without maintaining a large inventory. I paid off most of my street-level dealers and told them to find other work for a while.

The money stopped flowing in, which was painful after months of increasing revenue. But I reminded myself that it was better to pause voluntarily than to have everything seized because I got arrested.

Raindrop supported the decision completely. "This is the smart play," she said one night as we counted the remaining cash and planned which safe deposit boxes to empty. "You're thinking long-term instead of just chasing the next

dollar."

"Doesn't feel smart. Feels like I'm giving up everything I built."

"You're not giving it up, you're protecting it. There's a difference. If Chris really did tell narcotics about your operation, they're building a case right now. But if they don't have any current activity to observe, if all they have is old information that can't be corroborated, the case falls apart."

She was right, of course. But it still felt like failure.

Two weeks into the shutdown, T. called.

"Heard you've been having problems," he said without greeting.

"Word travels fast."

"Always does. Want to tell me what's going on?"

I explained the Chris Johnson situation, the Reaper connection, my decision to pause operations. T. listened without

interrupting.

"You did the right thing," he said when I finished. "Most guys your age, they'd keep pushing, thinking they're invincible. You recognized the threat and adapted. That's maturity."

"Doesn't feel like maturity. Feels like I'm running scared."

"There's a difference between running scared and making strategic retreats. You'll learn that as you get older, assuming you live that long." He paused. "I'm coming back next month. Been gone long enough, and the DA's case went nowhere. When I get back, we should talk about that partnership. Because the way you handled this situation tells me you've got the judgment for the next level."

"What's the next level?"

"Distribution, not just dealing. You've been buying from Flaco and selling to Ray and

your street dealers. Next level is cutting out the middle men, going straight to the source. Bigger risks, but bigger rewards. And more importantly, more control over your supply chain."

This was what I'd been working toward, but the timing felt wrong. "T., I just shut down my operation because of security concerns. Now you want me to expand?"

"Not expand - evolve. Look, you're always gonna have security concerns in this business. Always gonna be some Chris Johnson running his mouth or some Reaper trying to move in on your territory. You can't let that paralyze you. You deal with each threat as it comes up, you adapt, and you keep moving forward."

"I'll think about it."

"You do that. But Easton? Time moves fast in this game. Opportunities don't wait around. You pause too long, someone else

steps into the space you left behind."

After he hung up, I sat in the RV thinking about his words. He was right - even now, with my operation mostly shut down, I could feel other dealers moving into my territory. Clients I'd been supplying for months were finding new sources. Street corners I'd controlled were being worked by competitors.

The game didn't stop just because I pressed pause. It kept moving, with or without me.

Chapter 10: The Cost of Business

Three weeks into my self-imposed shutdown, Flaco called with unexpected news.

"We need to talk. In person. Tonight."

His tone was serious enough that I didn't ask questions. We agreed to meet at a different location than usual - a 24-hour diner off Highway 146, public enough to

be safe but private enough for sensitive conversation.

Flaco was already there when I arrived, sitting in a back booth with a cup of coffee he wasn't drinking. He looked tired, older somehow than the last time I'd seen him.

"Thanks for coming," he said as I slid into the booth across from him. "I know you've been laying low, but this couldn't wait."

"What's going on?"

"Your boy Chris Johnson? He didn't just run his mouth at the Kick Back. He was working with narcotics. Wearing a wire, setting people up, the whole thing."

My blood ran cold. "How long?"

"At least two months, maybe more. He flipped after getting popped with half a pound back in June. Been feeding them information ever since."

"How do you know this?"

Flaco pulled out his phone and showed me

a photo - a police report, partially redacted, but clearly showing Chris Johnson's name as a confidential informant. "I got people inside the department. Cost me \$5,000 to get this, but I figured you'd want to know." I stared at the photo, my mind racing. If Chris had been wearing a wire for two months, that meant he'd potentially recorded conversations about the Ray deal, about my increased orders from Flaco, about everything.

"Do they have enough to make arrests?" I asked.

"My guy says they're close but not quite there. They've got Chris's testimony and whatever recordings he made, but a good lawyer could tear that apart - Chris is a drug addict with a record, not exactly a credible witness. What they need is to catch someone in the act, make a

controlled buy or witness a transaction."

"Which they can't do if there are no transactions," I said, relief flooding through me. My decision to shut down operations might have saved me from a prison sentence.

"Exactly. But here's the thing - they know you're the target they really want. Chris gave them enough to know you're moving serious weight, but not enough to prove it in court. So they're gonna keep watching you, waiting for you to start up again."

"How long do they wait?"

Flaco shrugged. "Depends on their budget and priorities. Could be weeks, could be months. But eventually, if you don't give them anything, they'll move on to easier targets."

"What about you? Did Chris know about our arrangement?"

"He knew you were getting product from

someone in Houston, but he didn't know who. I'm careful about that shit. And I stopped taking meetings with anyone I didn't know personally after hearing about Chris."

I thought about Chris lying in that hospital bed, beaten by Reaper's guys. Now I understood why - Reaper must have found out Chris was working with the cops and decided to send a message. The beating wasn't about Chris running his mouth to random people; it was about him running his mouth to narcotics.

"Does Reaper know about the wire?" I asked.

"If he doesn't, he's about to. Word's spreading fast. Every dealer in Houston and Baytown is gonna know Chris was an informant by the end of the week."

"Then Chris is a dead man."

"Probably. Narcotics will try to protect him,

maybe relocate him, but guys like Chris usually end up dead within a year. Either the people he snitched on find him, or he goes back to using and overdoses. It's just a matter of time."

We sat in silence for a moment, both contemplating the implications. I thought about the \$5,000 I'd offered Chris to leave town. That money might have actually saved his life if he'd taken it and run far enough, fast enough.

"What are you gonna do?" Flaco asked.

"Same thing I've been doing - nothing. I stay shut down, keep my head down, wait for them to lose interest. It's boring and it costs me money, but it keeps me out of prison."

"Smart. Most guys, they'd panic, make a run for it or try to intimidate witnesses. That just gives the cops more charges to pile on."

"T. taught me that. He said the best way to beat a case is to never give them a case to begin with."

Flaco smiled slightly. "T.'s a smart man. You learn from him, you might actually survive this business."

After Flaco left, I sat in the diner for another hour, drinking coffee and processing everything. Chris had been an informant for at least two months. That meant every conversation we'd had, every transaction he'd witnessed, potentially every bit of information I'd shared with him had been passed along to narcotics. I pulled out my phone and called my lawyer. "Mr. Easton," he answered. "Little late for a social call." "Not social. I need advice. Hypothetically, if someone found out a former associate had been working as a confidential

informant, what should their response be?"

"Hypothetically," my lawyer said carefully, "they should do absolutely nothing. Don't contact the person, don't try to find out what they said, don't discuss it with other associates. Maintain complete silence on the subject. Any action you - hypothetically speaking - might take could be construed as witness tampering or intimidation, which is a federal charge."

"What if narcotics is building a case based on this informant's testimony?"

"Then you do nothing and wait. If they had enough to arrest you, they already would have. The fact that they haven't means they're hoping you'll make a mistake, give them something concrete to work with. Don't give it to them."

"How long do I wait?"

"As long as it takes. I know it's frustrating, but patience is your best defense right

now. Live a quiet life, don't engage in any illegal activities, and eventually they'll move on to easier targets."

After hanging up with my lawyer, I called an emergency meeting with my inner circle. This time we met at a park near the bay, walking along the trails where surveillance would be difficult.

I told them everything - Chris being an informant, the potential case being built, Flaco's warning. Their reactions ranged from anger to fear to resignation.

"So what you're saying is we're done," Tony said flatly. "All of this, everything we built, it's over."

"Not over," I corrected. "Paused. There's a difference."

"For how long? Months? Years?"

"However long it takes for narcotics to give up or for the evidence to become too old to use. My lawyer says if we stay clean

for six months to a year, any case they're building falls apart."

"A year," Tony repeated. "Easton, I can't wait a year. I got bills, I got debts, I got people depending on me."

"Then you go back to Mobile and do whatever you gotta do. But you don't do it through me, not until this situation is resolved."

Tony looked like he wanted to argue, but Big C. cut him off. "Easton's right. We knew getting into this that it could end any time. Prison, death, or retirement - those are the only ways out. At least this way, we're choosing when and how."

"Doesn't feel like a choice," lil C. muttered.

"It is though," I said. "We could keep operating, roll the dice and hope narcotics doesn't have enough to make arrests.

Some of us might get away with it. But some of us would definitely go down. This

way, we all walk away clean. We take our money, we lay low, and we live to fight another day."

Rob had been quiet through most of the conversation, but now he spoke up. "What about Reaper? He knows about Chris being an informant, which means he knows Chris might have talked about the beatdown we gave him. Reaper might decide to come after us before the cops do."

I'd thought about this too. "If Reaper was gonna move on us, he would've done it already. The fact that he hasn't tells me he's got the same problem we do - he can't risk the attention. Any violence right now just gives narcotics more ammunition."

"So we all just sit around and wait?" J.D. asked.

"We sit around and wait. It's not

glamorous, but it keeps us out of prison." Nobody was happy about it, but everyone understood. We'd pushed the game as far as we could push it, and now we were hitting the natural limits. The question was whether we could be patient enough to let the heat die down before we made our next move.

Over the following weeks, I established a new routine. No dealing, no meetings with clients, no discussions about business over the phone or in person. I worked on my bike, helped J.D. with his automotive projects, spent time with Raindrop. It was the most normal my life had been in years. But normal felt wrong. I'd gotten used to the rush of adrenaline that came with major deals, the satisfaction of building something from nothing. Now I was just... existing. Waiting for something to happen, good or bad.

The money in my safe deposit boxes provided a cushion, but it wouldn't last forever. I'd been burning through about \$3,000 a month on basic expenses, and while I had enough saved to last a couple years if I was careful, the thought of depleting my reserves without any income was terrifying.

T. called again about six weeks into my shutdown.

"How you holding up?" he asked.

"Going crazy with boredom, but otherwise fine."

"Yeah, waiting's the hardest part. But you're doing the right thing." He paused. "I'm back in town, by the way. Laying low myself, but around if you need anything."

"How'd your situation work out with the DA?"

"They dropped it. Couldn't make anything stick without direct evidence, and I'd been

careful enough that they couldn't find any. They know what I am, but knowing and proving are two different things."

"Must be nice."

"It is. But Easton, I didn't call just to check in. I've got some information you need to hear. About Chris Johnson."

My stomach tightened. "What about him?"

"He's dead. Overdose, supposedly. Found him in a motel room in Louisiana three days ago."

I sat down heavily, processing this news.

"Overdose?"

"That's what the report says. But the timing's suspicious - he disappears right after word spreads that he's an informant, turns up dead a few weeks later in a place nobody knew he was going? My guess is someone found him and made it look like an overdose."

"Reaper?"

"Maybe. Or one of the other people Chris informed on. He was working with narcotics for months - could be dozens of people who wanted him dead."

"Does this change anything for me?"

"It might. Without Chris to testify, any case narcotics was building just got a lot weaker. They'll still have his recordings, but like I said before, that's not always enough without a live witness. Give it another few months, make sure they're not setting up a grand jury, and you might be in the clear."

After T. hung up, I told Raindrop about Chris.

"Do you feel bad?" she asked.

"I don't know. Part of me thinks he brought it on himself - you snitch in this game, there are consequences. But another part of me remembers him lying in that hospital bed, beaten half to death, and

wonders if he ever really had a choice."

"He had choices. They might not have been good choices, but he had them."

"Yeah. And he made the wrong ones, and now he's dead."

We were quiet for a while, both lost in our own thoughts. Chris Johnson had been a cautionary tale from the beginning - someone who couldn't handle the drugs he was selling, couldn't keep his mouth shut, couldn't play the game at the level it needed to be played. His death wasn't surprising, just inevitable.

But it was also a reminder that this business had real consequences. Prison sentences, violence, death - they weren't abstract concepts. They were real outcomes that happened to real people I knew.

"You still want to go back when this is over?" Raindrop asked quietly.

"I don't know," I admitted. "Part of me misses it - the money, the respect, the feeling of building something. But another part of me is enjoying the peace. Not worrying every day about getting arrested or killed. Actually sleeping through the night."

"You don't have to decide now. You've got time to figure out what you really want."

She was right. For the first time in years, I had time. Time to think, time to plan, time to consider whether the life I'd been living was really the life I wanted.

The question was whether I'd have the wisdom to make the right choice when the time came.

End of Part Two

The story continues to explore Mr. Easton's journey through the dangerous world of methamphetamine distribution, the consequences of his choices, and the

delicate balance between ambition and survival. His decisions in the coming months will determine whether he rises to T.'s level or becomes another cautionary tale like Chris Johnson.